

A War of Nerves

The Cold War • 1945–1991 | Standards US.59, US.60, US.61, US.62, US.63, US.64, US.65, US.66, US.67, US.68, US.69, US.70

Name _____

- Archive (J. Troop)
- Spark
- Navigator
- Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

For nearly half a century, the two most powerful nations on earth pointed enough weapons at each other to end the world — and never quite fired. The Cold War was fought with spies, propaganda, proxy wars, and fear instead of direct battle. How do you 'win' a war nobody dares to fight? And what does a democracy risk losing — at home — when it spends fifty years afraid?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories.

Cold War	_____	containment	_____
	_____		_____
McCarthyism	_____	brinkmanship	_____
	_____		_____
MAD (Mutually Assured Destruction)	_____	proxy war	_____
	_____		_____
détente	_____	Iron Curtain	_____
	_____		_____

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Your read & evidence
1	Analyze the origins of the Cold War and the U.S. strategy of containment (Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, Berlin Airlift, NATO). Notice: Yesterday's ally is today's enemy. The moment the shooting stopped in 1945, the two nations that had just beaten Hitler together turned to face... Debrief: Explain how the Cold War began and what 'containment' meant. Give two examples of early containment policies and how each worked.	
2	Analyze the Second Red Scare and McCarthyism — HUAC, the blacklist, and the Rosenberg case — as a civil-liberties crisis born of Cold War fear. Notice: Someone points at you and says you're the enemy. They have no proof — just a claim — but the claim alone is enough to get you fired, blacklisted... Debrief: Explain what McCarthyism was and how it harmed Americans, using HUAC and the blacklist. Then explain the tension the Rosenberg case reveals: how can it be true both that Soviet spies existed AND that the Red Scare went too far?	
3	Analyze the causes, course, and outcome of the Korean War — containment's first shooting test. Notice: A line on a map, drawn in a hurry, splits a country in two — communist on one side, not on the other. Then one morning the tanks roll across it... Debrief: Explain how the Korean War tested the U.S. strategy of containment, and describe its outcome. Why was Truman's decision to fire MacArthur significant?	
4	Analyze Eisenhower's strategy of brinkmanship and the nuclear arms race that filled American life with the fear of sudden annihilation. Notice: Your teacher stops class, and everyone crawls under their desks and covers their heads — practicing for the end of the world. That was a normal... Debrief: Explain Eisenhower's strategy of brinkmanship and the idea of Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD). Then describe two ways nuclear fear shaped everyday American life. What was Eisenhower warning about with the 'military-industrial complex'?	
5	Analyze the Space Race as an arena of Cold War competition, from the shock of Sputnik to the Moon landing. Notice: One night in 1957, Americans went outside and looked up — and saw a Soviet machine crossing the sky. A little metal ball called Sputnik, beeping... Debrief: Explain why the launch of Sputnik alarmed Americans and how the U.S. responded. Then explain how the Space Race was really part of the Cold War, using the Moon landing as evidence.	
6	Analyze the Cuban Revolution, the Bay of Pigs, and the Cuban Missile Crisis — the closest the world came to nuclear war. Notice: Thirteen days. For thirteen days in October 1962, the entire human race was closer to nuclear annihilation than it has ever been before or since —... Debrief: Explain how the Cuban Missile Crisis began and how it was resolved. Why is it considered the most dangerous moment of the Cold War, and what did the two sides do afterward to reduce the risk of nuclear war?	
7	Analyze the causes and course of the Vietnam War and the roles of Kennedy, Johnson, and Nixon in escalating and ending it. Notice: You're nineteen, drafted, and dropped into a jungle on the other side of the planet to fight an enemy you can't see, for a village that isn't sure... Debrief: Explain why the U.S. could not win in Vietnam despite its military superiority. Then summarize how Kennedy, Johnson, and Nixon each handled the war. Why is Linh's perspective important to understanding it?	
8	Analyze the antiwar movement and the deep divisions the Vietnam War created on the American home front. Notice: For the first time in history, Americans could watch a war on television during dinner — the real thing, blood and all, every single night. And... Debrief: Explain why the Vietnam War so deeply divided the American home front. Give two causes of the antiwar movement, and then explain — fairly — why some	

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Your read & evidence
	Americans saw the protests as betrayal. Can you honor both the soldier and the protester?	
9	Analyze détente and the eventual peaceful end of the Cold War, from Nixon's diplomacy to the fall of the Berlin Wall. Notice: After decades of pointing weapons at each other, the two superpowers did something almost stranger than war: they started talking. And then, one... Debrief: Explain what détente was and give two examples. Then explain how the Cold War finally ended. Why is it significant that it ended largely without direct war between the superpowers?	

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 7 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **American transport planes at Berlin's Tempelhof Airport during the 1948–49 Berlin Airlift, which supplied 2.5 million blockaded West Berliners entirely by air.**

- Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?

- Spark's question: *These are American planes at Berlin during the 1948–49 airlift, feeding a blockaded city entirely from the air. Ask: the U.S. beat the Berlin...*

- What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Toward ↗ or away ↘?	Why — your evidence
1948	The Berlin Airlift		_____
1950	The Korean War		
1954	The peak of McCarthyism		
1962	The Cuban Missile Crisis		
1969	Apollo 11 lands on the Moon		
1975	The fall of Saigon ends the Vietnam War		
1989	The Berlin Wall falls		

B Debrief & Closing Argument

The Cold War is the 'more perfect union' question turned inward. For nearly fifty years, the United States told the world it stood for freedom...

Closing question: The Cold War asked Americans to defend freedom abroad while fear tempted them to shrink it at home. Choose one example where the U.S. lived up to its ideals in the Cold War and one where fear led it to betray them, and argue what the whole era did to the nation's founding promise. Then take a position: did the U.S. 'win' the Cold War, and at what cost? Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:
